

Project 2: Enterprise System Selection and Adoption

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Executive Summary

Sierra Pacific Outfitters has reached a point where continued business growth is constrained by disconnected information systems. Separate applications for accounting, inventory, retail operations, e-commerce, and wholesale distribution have created duplicate data entry, inconsistent inventory records, delayed financial reporting, and limited visibility into organizational performance. To remain competitive before the next peak retail season, the company needs an enterprise platform capable of integrating these critical business functions while supporting future growth.

This report recommends Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central as the enterprise resource planning (ERP) platform that best satisfies Sierra Pacific Outfitters' operational and strategic objectives. The recommendation is supported by a weighted requirements matrix evaluating functionality, security, implementation complexity, vendor stability, scalability, and total cost of ownership. While Oracle NetSuite demonstrated comparable functionality and SAP Business One offered lower acquisition costs, Business Central provided the strongest balance of operational capability, cybersecurity, vendor maturity, and long-term value within the organization's planning envelope (Laudon & Laudon, 2024).

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Technology selection alone does not guarantee project success. Research identifies organizational change management, executive sponsorship, employee engagement, and structured training as critical success factors for ERP implementations (Umble et al., 2003). Accordingly, this report complements the platform recommendation with an adoption strategy built around the Prosci ADKAR model, including stakeholder communication, role-based training, pilot implementation, and measurable success criteria designed to encourage organization-wide adoption while minimizing operational disruption. Collectively, these recommendations position Sierra Pacific Outfitters to improve operational efficiency, strengthen decision-making through integrated data, and establish a scalable technology foundation capable of supporting continued organizational growth. The recommendations presented in this report provide Sierra Pacific Outfitters with a practical roadmap for selecting, implementing, and successfully adopting an ERP solution that supports both immediate operational improvements and long-term strategic growth.

Production (Gurdev)

Current Business Environment

Enterprise Resource Planning (ERP) systems integrate multiple business functions into a centralized information system that supports real-time data sharing, operational efficiency, and strategic decision-making (Laudon & Laudon, 2024). Organizations experiencing rapid growth frequently outgrow independent software applications because fragmented information systems create data inconsistencies, duplicate work, poor visibility, and delayed decision-making.

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Sierra Pacific Outfitters demonstrate many of these challenges. Each department currently operates with different software applications that exchange little or no information. Inventory personnel maintain spreadsheets while retail stores rely on independent POS systems. Finance operates within QuickBooks, whereas the e-commerce platform manages online sales independently. Consequently, the same information is entered multiple times into different systems, increasing the likelihood of human error and reducing operational efficiency.

Current operational challenges include:

- Inventory discrepancies between warehouse, retail stores, and website
- Three-week financial closing process
- Manual re-entry of wholesale orders
- Poor executive reporting
- Limited customer analytics
- Lack of real-time inventory visibility
- Duplicate purchasing activities
- Inconsistent pricing across sales channels
- Manual reconciliation of sales data
- Limited forecasting capabilities

These problems reduce organizational agility and prevent executives from making informed decisions based on accurate, real-time information.

Business Objectives

The proposed ERP implementation seeks to achieve the following strategic objectives:

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1. Integrate all core business operations into one enterprise platform.
2. Improve inventory accuracy to greater than 98%.
3. Reduce financial close time from three weeks to fewer than five business days.
4. Eliminate duplicate data entry.
5. Improve customer service through accurate inventory availability.
6. Support continued business growth without additional administrative staffing.
7. Improve executive reporting through real-time dashboards.
8. Strengthen cybersecurity and regulatory compliance.
9. Improve purchasing efficiency.
10. Increase profitability through improved operational visibility.

These objectives align with the company's long-term digital transformation strategy and directly address the operational issues identified in the project scenario.

Table 1, the weighted requirement matrix was assigned to reflect Sierra Pacific's stated pain points while also explicitly assigning weight to security, vendor risk, and cost efficiency within the approved TCO envelope.

Table 1

Weighted Requirement Matrix

#	Requirement	Weight	Rationale
1	Omnichannel inventory accuracy (stores + warehouse + web)	15%	The #1 stated pain point
2	Wholesale / B2B order automation	10%	Orders currently re-keyed by hand
3	Financial consolidation & close speed	15%	Books close 3 weeks late
4	POS / retail commerce capability	8%	6 physical stores need native POS

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5	Reporting & BI for executive questions	8%	Margin-by-channel, CLV take days today
6	Scalability (180 employees and growing)	7%	Company grew 40 → 180 in 5 years
7	Implementation complexity / time-to-value	7%	Must be fixed before peak season
8	Security & compliance (SOC 2, ISO 27001, NIST alignment)	10%	Vendor-risk criterion (NIST, 2024)
9	Vendor financial stability / risk	8%	Vendor-risk criterion
10	Cost efficiency / fit within the TCO envelope	12%	Must remain inside \$400K–\$750K

Candidate ERP Platforms

Following preliminary market research, three enterprise platforms were shortlisted for detailed evaluation.

Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central

Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central is a cloud-based ERP solution designed specifically for small and medium-sized organizations. It integrates finance, inventory management, purchasing, warehouse management, CRM, project management, and business intelligence into one unified platform. Native integration with Microsoft 365, Power BI, Power Platform, and Azure makes Business Central particularly attractive for organizations already using Microsoft technologies (Microsoft, 2025).

Advantages

- Excellent Microsoft ecosystem integration
- Advanced Power BI reporting
- Strong inventory management
- Multi-location warehouse support
- Retail-ready architecture

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- High scalability
- Strong cybersecurity

Oracle NetSuite ERP

Oracle NetSuite is a fully cloud-native ERP platform supporting financial management, CRM, inventory, warehouse operations, procurement, and e-commerce. It is widely recognized for organizations requiring advanced financial reporting and multi-subsidiary operations (Oracle, 2025).

Advantages

- Mature cloud platform
- Excellent financial reporting
- Strong wholesale distribution
- Advanced inventory management
- Global scalability

Disadvantages

- Higher licensing costs
- More expensive implementation
- Greater customization complexity

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SAP Business One

SAP Business One is designed primarily for growing small and medium-sized businesses requiring integrated financial management, inventory control, production planning, and purchasing. It provides strong operational capabilities but requires additional integration for advanced retail functionality (SAP, 2025).

Advantages

- Reliable ERP functionality
- Strong manufacturing support
- Stable vendor
- Flexible deployment

Disadvantages

- Less intuitive interface
- Additional customization required
- Weaker CRM capabilities

Shortlist and Scoring

Table 2 shows that a weighted decision matrix was developed to objectively compare candidate platforms. Three candidate platforms were evaluated against the matrix: Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central, Oracle NetSuite, and SAP Business One.

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Table 2

Shortlisting & Scoring Matrix

Requirement	Wt	Business Central	BC Wtd	NetSuite	NS Wtd	SAP B1	SAP Wtd
Inventory accuracy	15%	4	0.6	5	0.75	4	0.6
Wholesale/B2B automation	10%	4	0.4	5	0.5	3	0.3
Financial consolidation	15%	5	0.75	5	0.75	4	0.6
POS/retail capability	8%	3	0.24	4	0.32	3	0.24
Reporting/BI	8%	5	0.4	5	0.4	3	0.24
Scalability	7%	5	0.35	5	0.35	3	0.21
Implementation speed	7%	4	0.28	3	0.21	3	0.21
Security/compliance	10%	5	0.5	5	0.5	3	0.3
Vendor risk	8%	5	0.4	4	0.32	3	0.24
Cost efficiency	12%	4	0.48	2	0.24	5	0.6
TOTAL	100%		4.40		4.34		3.54

Recommendation

Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central is recommended, with a score of 4.40/5, narrowly ahead of Oracle NetSuite (4.34) and SAP Business One (3.54). While NetSuite scores marginally higher on raw functional capability, Business Central's advantage in security, vendor risk, and cost efficiency relative to the approved planning envelope makes it the platform offering the best overall balance of functionality, scalability, security, and cost (Laudon & Laudon, 2024). Vendor stability is a critical component of ERP selection because enterprise systems typically remain in service for 10–15 years, making product roadmap, cybersecurity

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maturity, and long-term support capability as important as day-one functionality (PMI, 2021; Gartner, 2024).

Security and Vendor Risk Assessment

Cybersecurity is a critical selection criterion because the ERP platform will centralize financial records, customer information, inventory data, supplier contracts, payroll information, and operational analytics. The selected vendor must demonstrate mature security controls and regulatory compliance. Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central provides enterprise-grade security through Microsoft Azure, including:

- Multi-factor authentication (MFA)
- Role-based access control (RBAC)
- Encryption of data at rest and in transit
- Continuous security monitoring
- Automatic cloud updates
- Microsoft Defender integration
- Disaster recovery and backup capabilities
- Compliance with standards such as ISO/IEC 27001, SOC 1, and SOC 2

Vendor risk was also assessed based on financial stability, long-term product support, implementation of partner availability, cloud infrastructure maturity, and roadmap continuity. Microsoft's extensive global ecosystem and long-term investment in Dynamics 365 reduce the likelihood of vendor instability compared with smaller ERP providers (Microsoft, 2025).

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Adoption & Change-Management Plan

Organizational resistance remains one of the leading causes of ERP implementation failure, and employee acceptance is one of the strongest predictors of ERP success (Kotter, 2012; Prosci, 2024a). This project adopts the Prosci ADKAR model, which emphasizes five sequential stages of individual and organizational change: Awareness, Desire, Knowledge, Ability, and Reinforcement (Prosci, 2024a).

Awareness. Executive leadership communicates the operational problems caused by disconnected applications and the business benefits of an integrated ERP.

Desire. Department managers participate in planning meetings and encourage employee involvement; early engagement reduces uncertainty and builds ownership of the change (Prosci, 2024b).

Knowledge. Role-specific training is delivered before go-live, covering financial processing, inventory management, purchasing, warehouse operations, retail sales, customer management, reporting, and mobile applications.

Ability. Employees receive hands-on training in a pilot environment before production go-live, supported on-site by trained super-users.

Reinforcement. Weekly support sessions, performance dashboards, refresher training, and recognition sustain the new behaviors after go-live. Kotter's eight-step model similarly emphasizes establishing urgency, building a guiding coalition, and generating short-term wins to sustain transformational change (Kotter, 2012).

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Communication Plan

Frequent, transparent communication reduces uncertainty and is strongly associated with higher ERP adoption rates (Kotter, 2012; Prosci, 2024b). Table 3 illustrates the communication plan.

Table 3

Communication Plan

Audience	Method	Frequency	Owner
Executive Team	Steering Committee Meeting	Weekly	Project Manager
Department Managers	Status Meeting	Weekly	Change Manager
Employees	Email Newsletter	Biweekly	HR
Warehouse Staff	Toolbox Meetings	Weekly	Warehouse Manager
Retail Staff	Store Meetings	Weekly	Store Managers
Vendors	Progress Reviews	Biweekly	ERP Consultant

Training Plan

Hands-on, role-based instruction has been identified as a critical success factor in ERP implementations (Umble et al., 2003). Table 4 demonstrates the training plan.

Table 4

Training Plan

Department	Duration	Delivery Method
Finance	5 Days	Classroom & Workshops
Warehouse	4 Days	Hands-on Training
Purchasing	3 Days	Workshops
Retail Stores	3 Days	Store-Based Training
Sales	2 Days	Virtual Sessions
Executives	1 Day	Dashboard Training
IT Support	5 Days	Technical Training

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Pilot Implementation Plan

Scope: One retail location, warehouse operations, finance department, inventory management, and purchasing.

Duration: Six weeks.

Success criteria: Inventory accuracy above 98%, financial close within five business days, order-processing time reduced by 30%, user satisfaction above 85%, and system uptime above 99.9%.

Lessons learned during the pilot guide for adjustments before enterprise-wide rollout.

Financial (J-Steven)

Selecting an enterprise resource planning (ERP) system requires more than comparing the initial purchase price. Executive leadership must understand the total cost of ownership (TCO), which includes software licensing, implementation, data migration, employee training, ongoing support, and financial risks over the system's expected life. Evaluating the complete financial picture allows Sierra Pacific Outfitters to choose an ERP solution that not only fits within the approved planning envelope but also provides long-term operational value.

Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central was evaluated using a three-year planning horizon because ERP implementations are long-term investments that continue to generate costs after deployment. The proposed financial plan remains within the company's approved planning budget of approximately \$400,000 to \$750,000 while supporting future organizational growth.

Table 5

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Three-Year Total Cost of Ownership (Planning Estimates)

Cost Category	Estimated Cost (USD)
Business Central Licensing (3 Years)	\$246,000
Implementation & Configuration	\$180,000
Data Migration	\$45,000
Employee Training	\$44,000
Support & Maintenance	\$75,000
Contingency Reserve	\$35,000
Estimated Three-Year TCO	\$625,000

Although the estimated three-year total cost of ownership is approximately \$625,000, the financial value of an enterprise resource planning (ERP) system extends beyond implementation costs alone. Shang and Seddon (2002) argue that ERP investments should be evaluated according to the operational, managerial, strategic, IT infrastructure, and organizational benefits they provide rather than solely through traditional return-on-investment calculations. As organizations mature in their use of enterprise systems, these benefits accumulate through standardized business processes, improved decision-making, and greater organizational agility.

For Sierra Pacific Outfitters, Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central is expected to reduce manual inventory reconciliation, shorten financial close cycles, improve purchasing visibility, and provide executives with integrated reporting capabilities. Collectively, these improvements strengthen operational efficiency while establishing a scalable enterprise platform

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capable of supporting continued organizational growth (Shang & Seddon, 2002; Hendricks et al., 2007).

Licensing Costs

Business Central uses a subscription-based licensing model that provides predictable annual operating expenses while allowing Sierra Pacific Outfitters to add users as the organization grows. Rather than making a large upfront software purchase, the company pays recurring licensing fees that include software updates, cloud hosting, and security improvements.

Implementation & Configuration

Implementation costs include system configuration, consulting services, project management, testing, quality assurance, and go-live support. Investing in experienced implementation assistance reduces project risk and helps ensure the ERP system supports finance, inventory, purchasing, warehouse operations, retail sales, and e-commerce.

Data Migration

Data from QuickBooks, spreadsheets, the point-of-sale system, and the e-commerce platform should be cleansed, validated, and tested before migration. This helps reduce duplicate records and improves confidence in the new ERP system.

Employee Training

Role-based training for finance, warehouse operations, purchasing, retail staff, executives, and IT personnel supports user adoption and reduces resistance to change.

Ongoing Support & Maintenance

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ERP implementations generally deliver benefits in stages. Organizations often realize operational improvements first through standardized workflows and integrated information before achieving broader managerial and strategic benefits as users become proficient with the system. Expected improvements for Sierra Pacific Outfitters include more accurate inventory records, faster financial reporting, improved purchasing coordination, enhanced executive decision-making, and greater scalability for future retail expansion. These outcomes align with research demonstrating that enterprise systems create value well beyond the implementation period (Shang & Seddon, 2002).

Financial Risks

Additional financial risks include temporary productivity losses during employee training, consulting overruns resulting from unforeseen customization requirements, and future subscription price adjustments. These risks can be mitigated through disciplined project governance, phased implementation, contingency funding, and continued executive oversight throughout deployment. Organizations that actively manage implementation risk while maintaining organizational support are more likely to realize the long-term benefits associated with ERP investments (Hendricks et al., 2007).

Environment & Stakeholders (Tiana)

Successful ERP implementations depend as much on organizational readiness as they do on technical capabilities. Although Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central was selected as the preferred platform, long-term project success will ultimately depend on stakeholder engagement, vendor reliability, and the organization's ability to manage change effectively. Research has consistently shown that employee acceptance, executive sponsorship, and

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communication are among the strongest predictors of ERP implementation success (Umble et al., 2003).

Stakeholders and Departmental Impact

Executive leadership serves as the project's sponsor by approving funding and establishing strategic priorities. Finance leadership plays an additional governance role by monitoring project expenditures, validating total cost of ownership assumptions, and ensuring the implementation remains within the approved budget. Department managers within Finance, Warehouse Operations, Purchasing, Retail Operations, Sales, and Information Technology are responsible for coordinating departmental participation, supporting employee adoption, and communicating operational requirements throughout the implementation process.

Frontline employees represent the largest stakeholder group because they will transition from familiar legacy applications to integrated ERP workflows. Their willingness to adopt new processes will significantly influence project success. To reduce resistance, employees should participate in role-specific training, pilot testing, and continuous feedback sessions before organization-wide deployment.

Technology vendors also represent critical external stakeholders. Microsoft provides the ERP platform and cloud infrastructure, while implementation partners assist with migration, configuration, training, and technical support. Vendor performance directly affects implementation quality, system availability, and long-term support capabilities.

Vendor Risk

Although Microsoft is recognized as a financially stable vendor with a mature cloud platform, vendor-related risks remain during implementation. Delays in software configuration,

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migration support, licensing changes, or implementation consulting could extend project timelines or increase costs. To reduce these risks, Sierra Pacific Outfitters should establish clearly defined implementation milestones, monitor vendor performance throughout each project phase, and maintain contingency plans should implementation schedules significantly deviate from expectations.

Organizational Dynamics

Organizational resistance is expected because several departments currently rely on independent applications and manual processes that employees have used for years. Finance personnel may prefer existing QuickBooks workflows, warehouse employees currently depend heavily on spreadsheets, and retail staff must adapt to new inventory and reporting processes. Early communication regarding project goals, combined with department-specific training and leadership support, can reduce uncertainty and encourage user acceptance throughout implementation (Kotter, 2012).

Decision Thresholds

Several predefined thresholds should trigger reassessment of either the selected platform or the adoption strategy.

Table 6

Project Governance Decision Thresholds

Trigger	Executive Action
Vendor delay > 30 days	Reassess implementation timeline and partner support
Project cost > 15% over TCO	Executive budget review
Pilot adoption < 80%	Extend pilot and additional training
Executive sponsor departure	Appoint replacement sponsor immediately

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Establishing these thresholds allows Sierra Pacific Outfitters to respond proactively to changing project conditions while maintaining strategic alignment. This planning also directly addresses the potential risks introduced through the project scenario, including pilot resistance and leadership turnover, ensuring the organization remains prepared to adapt without compromising overall implementation success.

Alternative (J-Steven)

Although Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central fits within the approved planning budget, executive leadership requested an assessment of how the project would proceed if funding were reduced by 25 percent. Rather than replacing the recommended ERP platform, the project team recommends maintaining the core implementation while postponing lower-priority features until additional funding becomes available.

Table 7

Budget Comparison

Budget Scenario	Amount
Original Three-Year Budget	\$625,000
25% Budget Reduction	\$468,750

Table 8

Core Components to Retain

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Core Functionality	Reason for Retention
Business Central ERP Platform	Central system supporting business operations
Financial Management	Improves reporting and close time
Inventory Management	Resolves inventory discrepancies
Purchasing	Eliminates duplicate purchasing
Warehouse Management	Improves fulfillment
Data Migration	Preserves historical data
Security Controls	Protects company and customer data
Employee Training	Supports adoption

Table 9

Features Deferred to Phase II

Deferred Feature	Reason for Delay
Advanced Power BI Dashboards	Core reporting remains available
CRM Enhancements	Implemented after stabilization
AI-Powered Analytics	Not required for initial operations

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Workflow Automation	Added after core processes mature
Power Platform Integrations	Deferred until future growth
Advanced Reporting Customization	Standard reports meet initial needs

Revised Financial Strategy

A phased implementation prioritizes business-critical capabilities while delaying advanced customization and optional enhancements until additional funding becomes available.

Business Impact

Maintaining finance, inventory management, purchasing, warehouse operations, security, and employee training ensures that Sierra Pacific Outfitters addresses its highest-priority operational challenges despite the reduced budget. These capabilities directly support inventory accuracy, financial reporting, purchasing efficiency, and enterprise visibility, allowing the organization to achieve the primary objectives identified during system selection.

While postponing advanced reporting customization, AI-powered analytics, workflow automation, and expanded CRM functionality delays some strategic capabilities, these features primarily enhance existing business processes rather than enable core operations. As additional funding becomes available, deferred modules can be implemented without replacing the ERP

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platform, preserving long-term scalability while minimizing immediate implementation risk (Shang & Seddon, 2002).

Response to Injected Events

Enterprise system implementations don't always go according to plan. When surprises do occur, it's important that your organization knows how to react in order to uphold project goals, stakeholder confidence, and implementation velocity (Nah & Kuang, 2023). Because the team defined governance limits, communication strategies, training methods, and backup funds during the initial planning, any disruption can be handled through established project procedures instead of scrambling. The following scenarios demonstrate the project team's strategies for addressing each event and continuing to advance the Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central implementation.

Table 10

Injected Event Decision Log

Injected Event	Decision	Project Impact
Microsoft increases licensing costs	Renegotiate pricing and reassess the weighted requirements matrix before considering Oracle NetSuite	Minor financial impact if within approved thresholds
Warehouse employees resist ERP adoption	Extend warehouse pilot, increase training, and strengthen stakeholder communication	Localized schedule extension with improved user adoption

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Data migration issues occur	Pause migration, validate and cleanse data, then resume implementation	Short schedule adjustment while protecting data integrity
Executive sponsor leaves	Appoint a replacement sponsor immediately and continue project governance	Minimal impact to project continuity

Event 1: Microsoft Increases Licensing Costs

Vendor price increases were listed as an implementation risk in the project team's stakeholder plan. Should this occur during final negotiations with Microsoft, the initial course of action would be to negotiate pricing and recalculate the total cost of ownership and weighted requirements matrix. Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central had the highest overall score (4.40), but only marginally beaten out Oracle NetSuite (4.34). As such, the project team would first ensure that increased licensing fees do not dramatically impact the platform's overall value. Given the relatively insignificant gap between the two ERPs (0.06 points), even a small price increase would prompt the team to revisit the cost-efficiency criterion to ensure that Business Central maintains the highest overall ranking.

Provided the updated pricing falls within the project's predefined budget range, Business Central would still be recommended as it would offer the best options across vendor stability, security, implementation efficiency, and total value. Should that price surpass the team's accepted range, executive leadership would review and decide if Oracle NetSuite would be a better investment in the long run. Taking these steps would allow the team to recommend a solution based on the metrics rather than making a decision based on a vendor price increase.

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Event 2: Warehouse Employees Resist Using the ERP System

There is a risk that warehouse employees will cling to their current processes and spreadsheets during pilot implementation and resist using the new ERP system. Instead of forcing go-live, the project team would implement the change management plan by increasing warehouse-specific training and delaying go-live for that group until buy-in is achieved. Warehouse-focused training would be supplemented with hands-on exercises showing employees how inventory, receiving and fulfillment tasks can be accomplished in Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central. Toolbox meetings would be held twice per week instead of once per week to allow employees to ask questions, provide feedback, and receive additional coaching from supervisors and super users. The length of the warehouse portion of the pilot would be increased by 2 weeks while the rest of the implementation continues on schedule. Additional training expenses and temporary support would be covered by using contingency funds from the project budget without impacting the ERP recommendation.

Event 3: Data Migration Issues During Pilot Testing

If legacy financial, inventory, and customer information could not be migrated cleanly after pilot testing, the project team would pause migration efforts to safeguard data quality before proceeding with implementation. The implementation team would isolate the cause of migration errors, scrub legacy records, validate the cleansed data, and conduct additional testing. The migration would recommence once data has been proven to migrate accurately. Shortening the deployment schedule to ensure information accuracy will cause less harm than implementing an ERP system filled with incorrect information. Shortening the deployment schedule to ensure information accuracy will cause less business disruption than implementing an ERP system with

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unreliable data (Project Management Institute, 2021). While this may push back the implementation timetable marginally, it safeguards the system's integrity and limits post-go-live business disruption. Microsoft Dynamics 365 Business Central will remain in use since this fix addresses data quality issues rather than problems with the ERP software itself.

Event 4: Executive Sponsor Leaves the Organization

In the event that an executive sponsor departs during implementation, organizational leadership would be poised to assign a new sponsor. The Project Manager would facilitate transition documentation for the new sponsor which would include approved project objectives, implementation progress, budget status, risks and upcoming milestones. Current governance meetings, stakeholder communications, and project reporting would remain constant to ensure ongoing confidence from department heads, employees, vendors and implementation partners. With established communication channels and project governance in place, the departure of an executive sponsor would cause minimal operational impact. Visible executive support boosts employee confidence and ensures the implementation stays aligned with strategic goals.

Summary

Hopefully, these injected events have shed light on how crucial it is to plan ahead when working on enterprise system implementations. Setting governance thresholds, contingency funding, stakeholder communications plans, change management, and more before starting an implementation will allow project teams to overcome unforeseen obstacles while staying on track with the project goals. Instead of making rushed decisions, there will be a plan that each decision can fall back on that was created throughout the course of the project. This approach builds organizational resilience, ultimately paving the way for a successful Microsoft Dynamics

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365 Business Central rollout. “For by wise guidance you can wage your war, and in abundance of counselors there is victory.” (New American Standard Bible, 2020, Proverbs 24:6).

Reflection & Results (Lewis)

This section compares the planned Business Central down-selection and pilot with the actual outcomes resulting from the project's injected events. The technical and financial planning presented earlier in this report, including the weighted requirements matrix, total cost of ownership (TCO) estimate, and pilot success criteria, remained largely on track. The primary variance arose from the human side of implementation, as warehouse staff were slower than expected to transition from familiar spreadsheet-based processes to the new system.

Table 11

Planned vs. Actual Comparison

Dimension	Planned	Actual
Pilot duration (warehouse workstream)	6 weeks, uniform across all pilot groups.	Extended 8 weeks for warehouse staff (+33%) after go-live resistance.
Warehouse training	4 days, role-based, delivered before go-live per Table 4.	4 days baseline plus supplemental hands-on sessions funded from contingency reserve.
Toolbox meeting cadence (warehouse)	Weekly, per Table 3 communication plan.	Increased twice weekly during the resistance period.
Data migration	Single migration pass completed within the 6-week pilot window.	Migration paused mid-pilot for cleansing and revalidation before resuming.
Contingency reserve	Reserved for licensing, customization,	Partially drawn down to fund extended

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(\$35,000, per financial section)	and cost-overflow risk.	warehouse training and support, not the cost risks it was originally sized for.
Executive sponsorship	Continuous single sponsor through go-live per governance plan.	Sponsor departed mid-implementation; replacement appointed with transition documentation.
Pilot success criteria (inventory accuracy, close time, satisfaction, uptime)	All five thresholds in Table 4 met at or before go-live.	Technical thresholds tracked plan; user satisfaction threshold was the metric placed at risk by warehouse resistance.

Where Resistance Appeared.

The Adoption & Change Management Plan assumed that ADKAR-based training and weekly toolbox meetings would enable warehouse staff to adopt Business Central within the six-week pilot. Instead, employees continued using spreadsheets alongside the new system. Because Business Central scored highly for inventory and warehouse capabilities in the evaluation, the resistance reflected user behavior rather than system fit. This aligns with research showing that resistance to change reduces user satisfaction regardless of technical performance and can negatively affect otherwise successful ERP implementations (Ahmed et al., 2006; Akkermans & van Helden, 2002).

How the Team Responded.

Instead of forcing the original go-live date, the team followed its change-management plan by extending warehouse training, increasing toolbox meetings to twice weekly, and lengthening the warehouse pilot by two weeks while the rest of the implementation stayed on schedule. The additional effort was funded from the project's \$35,000 contingency reserve. This approach aligned with the project's governance thresholds, which prioritized meeting adoption

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criteria over maintaining the original timeline, and reflects ERP best practices that emphasize phased training and frequent user engagement to overcome resistance (Aladwani, 2001).

What the Variance Reveals.

The primary variance was in user adoption, not the technology itself. Data migration, platform selection, and financial planning remained close to expectations, while the assumption that one round of training and weekly check-ins would achieve adoption within six weeks proved unrealistic. This supports research showing that ERP success depends on sustained change management, employee acceptance, and progression through each stage of the ADKAR model rather than training alone (Kotter, 2012; Prosci, 2024a, 2024b; Umble et al., 2003; Mudjisatyo et al., 2024). For Sierra Pacific Outfitters' full rollout, the pilot demonstrates that change-management timelines and contingency budgets should be planned with the same emphasis as the technical implementation, since adoption, not technology was the project's greatest source of schedule and budget risk.

Overall, the pilot validated the Business Central recommendation from both technical and financial perspectives while highlighting a gap in adoption planning. Applying this lesson to the enterprise-wide rollout by allocating additional change-management time and contingency across all departments would create a more realistic implementation schedule and improve the likelihood of achieving inventory accuracy, financial close, and user satisfaction goals without repeating the pilot's delays. This lesson also reflects the principle of **Proverbs 15:22**: *"Without consultation, plans are frustrating, but with many counselors they succeed."* The team's willingness to gather feedback from warehouse staff, adjust the implementation approach, and involve stakeholders throughout the pilot strengthened the project and increased its chances of long-term success.

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Appendix

Executive Summary:

<https://chatgpt.com/g/g-p-6a52b688be888191bf364ea1ea2b8553/c/6a52b68b-4148-83e8-b45e-7af867133370>

Production: <https://chatgpt.com/c/7a703f01-8be0-83d8-b63c-491f83bf3718>

Financial and Alternatives: <https://chatgpt.com/c/6a6d8242-fdcc-83e8-8b2a-53d858bcc8f7>

Environment & Stakeholders:

<https://chatgpt.com/g/g-p-6a52b688be888191bf364ea1ea2b8553/c/6a52b68b-4148-83e8-b45e-7af867133370>

Injected Events: <https://claude.ai/share/c488295e-50f2-47d3-a1ee-5d904d542aca>

Reflection and Result: <https://claude.ai/share/9ae8dd64-574d-48ef-9ecd-801fbbe7d45a>